sufficient leverage with the countries. Johnson instructed his officials to let each side know that the US was supporting the UN secretary-general's call for a ceasefire.[216] On September 6, in retaliation for the Pakistani move across the ceasefire line, India attacked across the international border.[217] Johnson suspended military and economic assistance to both countries.[218]

Chinese involvement soon changed the American calculus about the stakes involved. The White House had received intelligence reports that the Rann of Kutch skirmishes and the Pakistani infiltration into Kashmir had been part of a plan that Pakistani officials had discussed with their Chinese counterparts.[219] Then, on September 4, Chinese foreign minister Chen Yi had held talks with his Pakistani counterpart in Karachi and publicly expressed support for Pakistan's actions—causing concern in India.[220] The CIA indicated that there might be a "secret Sino-Pakistani mutual defense agreement of some kind" that had been rumored to be in existence since early 1964. Analysts believed that it probably left Beijing enough flexibility to decide whether or not to use force to aid Pakistan, but felt that such an agreement would lead Pakistan to throw caution to the wind.[221] Around this time, in an effort to take the pressure off Pakistan, China rhetorically entered the fray, demanding that India remove its checkposts and troops near some sections of the Sino-Indian border.[222] A note also ominously warned, "India's aggression against any one of its neighbours concerns all of its neighbours."[223]

Before the war some US officials had questioned India's importance, but the potential Chinese threat made evident that India still had a place in the US framework for Asia. The US kept a close eye on Chinese actions, uncertain about what Beijing's declared support for Pakistan entailed.[224] Johnson and McNamara discussed their concern that China would go beyond threatening India. McNamara noted that the Defense Department was preparing for contingencies so the US would not be in "a terrible jam" if China intervened militarily.[225] Rusk laid out the stakes for Johnson: any escalation of the crisis would result in a setback to the American "effort to build … a viable counterweight to Communist China." If the Chinese got involved and India went "down the drain," it would affect the balance in Vietnam, and Japan and the Southeast Asian countries would see it as "a Communist victory over the US."[226] Coming as the crisis did during the Vietnam War, Komer concurred, asserting that if China did get involved